

Whatever their origin, early ventures into passenger transportation only survived because European governments were prepared to promote air travel. Contrary to the dream of the early aviators that flight would transcend borders and make redundant the division of the world into nation states, the 1919 Convention of Paris decreed that there was to be no “free and universal thoroughfare” of the air. This first attempt to lay down rules for international air traffic also stated clearly that each country had “complete and exclusive sovereignty over the airspace above its territory.” Indeed, the development of flight was entirely conditioned by national and imperial rivalries. European governments were persuaded of the need to encourage commercial aviation actively because they saw it as part of the struggle for national prestige and national defense. They recognized the need to maintain air technology

TRANSPORTATION PIONEER

This AEG J.II biplane is one of the aircraft with which Deutsche Luft-Reederei (DLR) began the first postwar European passenger air service in 1919. DLR was one of the forerunners of Lufthansa, which adopted the distinctive crane logo seen here on the tail.

and manufacturing capacity for possible future wars. And they saw in aircraft a means to bind together their far-flung empires.

European governments provided airlines with open or concealed subsidies – for example, through profitable airmail contracts – and introduced supportive regulations to encourage safety. They also intervened to protect airlines from competition, granting monopoly rights to fly certain routes and enforcing company mergers in line with their perception of the national interest.

The country that emerged as the leader in European – and therefore world – passenger air transportation in the 1920s was Germany. This was an especially impressive achievement since, for years after the war, the Allies continued to impose restrictions on German civil aviation, alongside the total ban on military aviation, under the terms of the Versailles Treaty. Germany

responded with a steely determination to maintain its aircraft industry.

To avoid restrictions – for a time German aircraft production was banned completely – manufacturers such as Junkers and Dornier relocated outside Germany. Fokker had already hastily shifted operations back to his native Netherlands at the war's end.

GERMAN NATIONAL AIRLINE

After the Nazis came to power in 1933, all Lufthansa airliners displayed the swastika. The aircraft shown in this poster, a Junkers Ju 52 was used as both a civil airliner and a military transportation.



First passenger airlines

The very first passenger service of the postwar era was initiated by German airline Deutsche Luft-Reederei on February 5, 1919 – three days before the French Farman company began a tentative service on the Paris to London route. Deutsche

Luft-Reederei flew between Weimar, where the assembly of the new German Republic was sitting, and the capital, Berlin. From these small beginnings, through the 1920s Germany developed a network of commercial air routes, stretching north into Scandinavia, east through Poland into the newly formed Soviet Union, and south into the Balkans and the Mediterranean. By 1923 these routes were being operated by just two airlines, one owned by Junkers and the other financed by shipping companies and bankers. In 1926 the German government, which was subsidizing both, forced them to merge into a single national airline, Deutsche Luft Hansa (DLH, known as Lufthansa after 1934).

When it was formed, Luft Hansa was by far the world's largest airline – it was estimated to be responsible for 40 percent of the world's passenger air traffic. It certainly operated with the most advanced aviation technology. In imitation of the US Air Mail, airways lighted by beacons were created for night flying. This allowed, for instance, a direct air service from Berlin to Moscow, traveling the lighted section from Berlin to Königsberg by night. By 1929, Luft Hansa pilots were routinely trained in instrument-flying, and aircraft were linked to air-traffic controllers by radio. By 1931, the airline was able to run a scheduled passenger service to Italy over the formidable barrier of the Alps.

